

Practice Paper 22 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — “Absurdly heavy” cards

Award **1 mark** for identifying the contrast between the literal lightness of the cards and the heaviness they seem to carry; **1 mark** for explaining that this reflects his **nervousness** / **fear** / **sense of pressure** about performing in front of a real audience.

Sample answer: The phrase suggests that, although a deck of cards is physically very light, the narrator’s **anxiety** about performing in front of the children made them feel like a great **burden** — the weight he feels is **emotional**, not physical.

Q2. [2] — Two details showing serious preparation

1 mark each for any two of:

- He had “practised in front of [his] bedroom mirror for two months.”
- He had practised in front of his “long-suffering grandmother.”
- He was wearing the proper “maroon polo shirt” of a hospital volunteer.
- He had memorised his uncle’s advice “the way other boys memorise football statistics” (acceptable from Paragraph 2 if the question is read generously, but reject if strictly from Paragraph 1).

Q3. [2] — The real trick (own words)

1 mark — The real skill is not the magical effect itself but the **art of distraction** / **drawing attention away** from what actually matters.

1 mark — It depends on small, subtle signals (a raised eyebrow, a pointing hand, a quiet word) that **guide where the audience looks** at the crucial moment.

Reject answers that simply lift “the small misdirection” without rewording.

Q4. [2] — Aisyah’s “steady, sceptical gaze”

1 mark — She is **cautious / distrustful / unwilling to be easily impressed**; she does not give her trust automatically.

1 mark — This is because, despite her young age, she has **already experienced disappointment** — adults have **promised her too many things** (presumably about her health or recovery) that did not turn out to be true.

Q5. [2] — “Loosened by a single notch”

1 mark — The narrator had been **tense and anxious** (“knotted”) from the moment he left the lift.

1 mark — Aisyah’s reaction of wonder gave him a **small but real burst of relief and growing confidence** — the tension did not vanish, but eased **slightly**, by **one step**.

Q6. [1] — Evidence of relaxing

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- “I began, very cautiously, to enjoy myself.”
- The mother “laughed so hard she had to look away.”
- The twins agreed about the coin trick — the narrator records this with humour.

Q7. [3] — Determined refusal (language question)

1 mark for identifying that the language makes the boy seem **deliberate / wilful / quietly resolute**; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “did not look up when I greeted him... did not look up when I fanned the cards” — the **repetition / parallelism** emphasises a **consistent, chosen refusal**.
- “fixed expression” — the word **fixed** suggests something **settled and immovable**, as though he has made up his mind.
- “decided, on some private principle” — the word **decided** makes the refusal sound **deliberate**, even **principled**, rather than passive sadness.
- “not to be cheered up by anyone in a maroon polo shirt” — the precise, almost mocking detail of the uniform shows he is rejecting the **whole performance**, not just the trick.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q8. [2] — “Try smaller”

1 mark — When an audience is **resistant or withdrawn**, pushing more energy at them only makes the situation **worse / more uncomfortable**.

1 mark — A **quieter, gentler, more modest** approach is more likely to **earn attention** from someone who has shut you out — restraint can succeed where effort fails.

Q9. [1] — Eyes flicking sideways

1 mark — It is the **first sign** that the boy is **secretly curious / paying attention** after all — a tiny crack in his refusal, which gives the narrator hope that the trick may be working.

Q10. [2] — “By perhaps a millimetre”

1 mark — The smile was **extremely small** / **barely visible** / **almost imperceptible**.

1 mark — Yet the **exaggerated precision** of the measurement shows how **significant** even this tiny reaction was to the narrator — for this particular boy, a millimetre of a smile was a **real victory**. (Accept: it shows the **gentle humour** with which the narrator now remembers the moment.)

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **reflective, grateful, quietly moved, humbled, thoughtful**. (Reject: **sad, triumphant** — these miss the gentle, reciprocal quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — Time spent on handwriting in the past

1 mark each for any two of:

- A child could expect to spend “a substantial portion of each week” on forming letters by hand.
- Loops were “traced and re-traced” / pencils were “sharpened and resharpened” (suggesting sustained, repeated effort).
- A teacher walked the rows correcting wrists individually (one-to-one attention).
- In the 1990s, pupils spent “over an hour” a day on handwriting (compared with under fifteen minutes today).

Q13. [2] — “Quietly retired”

1 mark — **Retired** suggests that the pencil has been **gently put aside** / **withdrawn from active use** — almost like an old worker reaching the end of a career.

1 mark — **Quietly** suggests that this change has happened **without any formal decision or public debate** — it has crept up on schools almost unnoticed.

Q14. [2] — Reasons teachers and parents welcome typing

1 mark each for any two of:

- Typed work is **faster to produce** and **easier to mark**.
- It is **easy to share** / send electronically.
- It eliminates problems of **smudged ink, lost pages, or unreadable handwriting**.
- Teachers are **overworked** with marking and welcome any time-saving.
- Parents see typing as a more **“future-ready”** skill for a screen-based working life.

Q15. [1] — Italicised “conceptual”

1 mark — The italics **emphasise the contrast** between **understanding the ideas** (conceptual memory) and merely **recording the words** (verbatim transcription). The handwriting group remembered the **meaning**, not just the text — and this is the point the writer wants the reader to grasp.

Q16. [2] — Why selecting and rephrasing helps learning (own words)

1 mark — Because the writer **cannot keep up word-for-word**, she is forced to **decide what matters** and **leave out what does not**.

1 mark — This act of **judgement and rewording** requires her to **process and understand** the material, rather than simply **copying it down** — and active processing is what **creates memory**.

Reject answers that lift “select, condense, and rephrase” without explanation.

Q17. [2] — Effect of “neurologically speaking”

1 mark — The qualifier shows the writer is being **precise and careful**: he is making a **specific scientific claim** about brain activity, not a sweeping cultural judgement.

1 mark — It also **protects him from overstatement** — he is not saying typing is harmful or worthless, only that the two activities use the brain **differently**. The qualifier signals balance and academic restraint.

Q18. [2] — Evidence of the “cultural counter-movement”

1 mark each for any two of:

- **Calligraphy classes** have “quietly multiplied” in major cities worldwide since the late 2010s.
- **Bullet-journaling** has spread among university students and office workers.
- **Sales of fountain pens** have grown for **six years in succession**, against expectation.

Q19. [2] — “The hand wants to make marks of its own”

1 mark — The phrase **personifies the hand**, treating it as having its **own desire** to write, draw or shape something physical.

1 mark — It suggests that returning to handwriting is not just sentimentality but answers a **deep human need to create**, to **make something visible and personal**, that a screen does not satisfy.

Q20. [2] — Purpose of mentioning children who benefit from typing

1 mark — The writer wants to show that his argument is **balanced** and **fair** — he is not blindly defending handwriting against all change.

1 mark — These examples **pre-empt the obvious objection** that he is being old-fashioned, and remind the reader that **typing genuinely opens opportunities** for children with disabilities or in remote areas — strengthening his credibility for the conclusion that follows.

Q21. [2] — “The pencil... has not yet had its last word”

1 mark — The image **personifies the pencil**, giving it a voice — as though it is a **person who still has something to say**.

1 mark — It is **effective** because it leaves the reader with a **hopeful, open-ended note**: the decline is not complete, the story is not over, and handwriting may yet **speak again** in the classrooms of the future.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Benefits of writing by hand (Paragraphs 3–4):

1. Students who write notes by hand **remember the concepts / meaning** of a lecture better a week later.
2. Because handwriting is **slower**, the writer cannot copy word-for-word and must **choose what is important**.
3. The act of **condensing and rephrasing** is itself a form of **active learning**.
4. Handwriting activates a **wider, more synchronised network** of brain regions linked to memory and learning.
5. Typing, by contrast, produces a **narrower pattern of brain activity**.

Cultural and practical reasons for the return of handwriting (Paragraph 5):

6. **Calligraphy classes** have multiplied in cities around the world.
7. **Bullet-journaling** has spread among university students and office workers.
8. **Sales of fountain pens** have **grown for six years running**, suggesting a real and sustained shift.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Writing by hand brings several benefits, beginning with sharper memory of ideas a week after a lecture. Because the pen is slower than the keyboard, the writer must choose, shorten and reword — and that effort itself deepens learning. Brain scans show handwriting lights up a wider network linked to memory than typing does. Culturally, calligraphy classes are multiplying in major cities, bullet-journaling has spread through universities and offices, and fountain-pen sales have risen for six straight years.

Length count: 78 words from “Writing” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —